of the Muslim invasions of the Indian subcontinent. Geography too played a role – the two countries were separated by the vast, cold desert of Tibet rimmed by the high peaks of the Himalayas, and equally by the vast ocean spaces that lay between India's coastal cities and China's east coast. While trade relations continued, these were never of a scale to leave behind a deep impression in either country of the other.

It was only during the period of British colonial rule over India that China encountered India once again, and this was not a pleasant experience. In the various British military assaults against China in the nineteenth century, it was Indian soldiers who served as the shock troops for the British. It was Indian opium traders who flaunted their wealth in the new urban centres of Shanghai and Hong Kong. The negativity that one encounters in Chinese attitudes towards India draws quite largely from this recent history.

During their dealings with China over the colonial period, the British accumulated a large amount of information about the country, its history and culture, but this did not percolate down to their Indian subjects. There were only a few Indian scholars during the colonial period who showed an interest in China, and a couple of Chinese scholars accepted Rabindranath Tagore's invitation to stay and teach in Santiniketan.[2] This meant that when India and China became, for the first time in history, next-door neighbours after China's occupation of Tibet in 1950, neither country had any close familiarity with the other.

The pathways to India's independence and China's liberation, respectively, traversed very different trajectories and aroused mutual admiration and scepticism in a complicated and variable mix. The geopolitical contestation, inevitable between two rising powers in Asia, was sharpened by the deep differences between the political systems each country chose. While independent India chose a liberal parliamentary democracy as its political dispensation, China became a one-party communist republic. This only compounded the lack of mutual understanding. Neither side invested enough in getting to know the other's history and culture and the drivers of their respective world views. For example, there was little appreciation in India that the revolt in Tibet in